Since 1963, China has refined its approach towards the Indian Subcontinent. As its economic might and political influence grew, so did its presence in India's neighbours, with all its attendant implications. For a nation that is so sensitive to developments in its own periphery, there has been little interest in addressing the natural concern of others in a similar situation. The relationship with Pakistan, in particular, has taken a quantum leap with the unfolding of the so-called China Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC). That this so-called corridor openly violates Indian sovereignty makes it even more unacceptable. While Sino-Pakistan collaboration is itself not recent, that cannot be said for the defence of Pakistan's more egregious actions. Blocking the sanctioning of self-confessed terrorists is taking place in isolation from the rest of the international community. It is a message that has naturally resonated negatively in India. At some stage, there could be a realization that this association with the worst face of Pakistan has its reputational costs. Until then, it will probably continue to cast its shadow.

The impact of a more powerful China will naturally be felt most on its immediate neighbourhood. In many cases, that also happens to be the periphery of India. The equilibrium between India and China is not going to be arrived at only bilaterally. It would also be shaped in different ways across a larger landscape. For India, this means stepping up its game in areas like connectivity and development projects. It has powerful cards in the form of geography, culture and societal contacts. How well it uses them all will be a real test of its strategy.

Any response obviously has to be predicated on the realization that greater ambitions and capabilities usually create a different behavioural pattern. Therefore, India too needs to think out of the box and find more creative methods of protecting its equities. If there is now an Indian willingness to break new ground, much of that derives from this perception. Interestingly, India's sense of independence is susceptible to exploitation in this regard. Words of caution that selectively draw on history can strike a chord with constituencies that are insecure. It is, therefore, essential that India has a clear-eyed view of its own interests and fashions its choices accordingly. In fact, the contemporary politics of China provides more than its fair share of lessons. At various times, it has concluded understandings with different